

Sport

FOOTBALL

Valletta relegated

25-time champions suffer first ever relegation after 0-4 drubbing by Naxxar

Twenty-five time champions Valletta suffered an historic first ever relegation to the Challenge League after suffering a humiliating defeat against Naxxar Lions. The 4-0 final scoreline terminated the Citizens slim hopes of avoiding the drop.

The once mighty Valletta now have to face this humiliating moment in its otherwise glorious history. This verdict was in the offing as Valletta struggled throughout the season always hoping in a last gasp football miracle.

After winning their 25th title after a historic penalty shoot-out win in a decider against Hibernians in 2019, the power of the Citizens was always on the downward trend, reaching the lowest ebb yesterday.

Valletta will now have to find the inner resources to recover from this terrible blow and try to gain immediate promotion to the Premier League and return where they belong.

Valletta needed the three points at stake against Naxxar to keep at least hoping till the final 90 minutes, but their hopes were shattered after barely two minutes play when Takuma Yamaguchi scored a stunner from the edge of the area completely beating Guarnone.

This was practically a knock out blow for Valletta who never recovered even if there was the whole match still to play. On ten minutes Naxxar almost doubled the score but



Photo: Nicholas Falzon

STANDINGS

	P	W	D	L	F	A	Pts
Hamrun S	25	19	4	2	60	15	61
Floriana	25	18	3	4	52	16	57
Sliema W	25	13	8	4	31	12	47
Marsaxlokk	25	12	7	6	40	22	43
Naxxar L	25	9	8	8	32	33	35
Birkirkara	25	9	8	8	26	25	35
Hibernians	25	9	7	9	28	27	34
Balzan	25	7	10	8	25	28	31
Gzira U	25	8	6	11	35	32	30
Santa Lucia	25	8	5	12	23	39	29
Mosta	25	6	10	9	17	32	28
Valletta	25	5	9	11	21	29	24
Sirens	25	3	7	15	17	47	16
Gudja U	25	0	6	19	12	62	6

BOV CHALLENGE LEAGUE	
Yesterday	
Senglea-Zabbar	0-0
St. Andrews-Lija	5-0
Tarxien-Luqa	3-3
Zebbug-Zejtun	1-0

SANTA LUCIA

2
F. Da Paz
D. Letherby
S. Pisani
T. Nagamatsu
D. Xuereb
J. Pisani
A. Mrdja
C. Moreira
A. Piazza
R. De Oliveira
S. Xerri

GZIRA

1
D. Zarkov
F. Conceicao
G. Bohrer
T. Aldama
Z. Scerri
Mariano
Macula
K. Spence
F. Romero
Z. Cassar
J. Mendoza

Referee: Ishmael Barbara

NAXXAR

4
M. Debono
N. Micallef
F. Barbosa
N. Pace
P. Servo
E. Cerqueira
R. Blandon
T. Yamaguchi
E. Espirito
Y. Ito
J. Moura

Referee
Malcolm Spiteri

BOV Player of the match
Pablo Augusto (Naxxar L)

VALLETTA

0
A. Guarnone
A. Ferraris
G. Braganca
J. Azzopardi
C. Gauci
K. Ewurum
F. Falcone
B. Paiber
P. Filho
A. Silas
D. Garba

Scorers: Yamaguchi 3', Pablo 32', Blandon 41', 65'
Yellow cards: Paiber, Yamaguchi, Elizeu, Jezdimirovic

BALZAN

0
R. Briffa
I. Bozovic
S. Arab
T. Caruana
P. Fenech
R. Michibuchi
N. Zerjal
N. Braunovic
O. Rommens
A. Andrejic
G. Blackwood

MOSTA

0
U. Akpan
S. Thomas
G. Chara
D. Aneni
H. Nwoga
A. Hovhannisyan
D. Ben Aziz
W. Britto
N. Agius
J. Vassallo
Z. Brincat

Referee: Fyodor Zammit

BIRKIRKARA

2
M. Zapytowski
E. Pepe
P. Mbong
A. Zammit
K. Zammit
A. Satariano
A. Coppola
N. Cross
E. Sarpong
S. Zibo
A. Diakite

SIRENS

2
E. Akpan
P. Boakye
N. Pulis
A. Panayiotou
M. Akadom
D. Murillo
K. Donsu
Kemm
K. Ntampizas
K. Muscat
D. Agius

Referee: Ezekiel Barbara